

PRANAB MUKHERJEE

Finance

Safe Hands

There are no quickfix solutions to an economic slowdown. Yet this veteran political warhorse is today expected to do just that—apply the healing gel to the deep ruptures left by a global financial tsunami. And that too with the “cool-headed” calculations he uses to troubleshoot for the Congress or answer questions from eager scribes, never giving away more than intended.

SHIPRA DAS



Priorities

- A bold reform stimulus which would rev up growth dynamics and propel the country towards the 9 per cent plus growth path.
- Step up investment in infrastructure.
- Stimulate demand by reducing personal income tax rates, tweak customs duty structure to accelerate exports.
- Tackle the fiscal deficit by shoring up government revenues and cutting down on borrowings.

Is he the one? Mukherjee boasts of a unique combination of political sensibility and allegiance to free market economics. He has the ability to balance the political need for pro-growth populism with the economic imperative of prudence. Given his vast experience and his understanding of the complex economic landscape, almost everyone expects him to deliver a dream budget in July and spur growth.

Style Statement

Loves music, especially Bengali folk.

▼ 70%

Delivery

0-34% 35-70% 71-100%



YASBANT NEGI

P. CHIDAMBARAM

Home Affairs

Home Again

Palaniappan Chidambaram may have won his Sivaganga seat by a whisker but that did nothing to diminish his confident swagger as he took over the reins of the Home Ministry on May 24, the only minister to have done so on a Sunday afternoon. And he called all the key officers of the ministry for a meeting the same evening. That more or less defines the way the 64-year-old Harvard educated lawyer runs the ministry. A Left supporter in the 1960s, Chidambaram became the face of economic reforms as the youngest finance minister in 1996 under H.D. Deve Gowda. Later, he got the finance portfolio again under the UPA Government in 2004.

Priorities

- Tackling terrorism, Naxalite violence and insurgency in the North-east.
- Full operationalisation of Multi-Agency Centre for better coordination and sharing of information among intelligence agencies.
- Modernisation of state police forces and filling vacancies, especially in the higher echelons.
- Operationalising the National Investigation Agency which was set up following the 26/11 Mumbai terror attacks.

Is he the one? Chidambaram may have been reluctant to take up the job of home minister but his iron grip is required to pull the ministry out of a deep rut. He needs to be a little less authoritarian in his dealings with other states and chief ministers. To monitor the security situation closely, he holds daily meetings with chiefs of intelligence agencies and heads of paramilitary forces.

Style Statement

Sports a spotless white *veshti* (dhoti). Loves to go for a drive in his car after office hours.

▼ 65%